

THE STATE OF AI

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE, A NEW FORM OF LIFE, A NEW STAGE IN EVOLUTION. SOME OF US FEAR ITS INCEPTION, OTHERS LOOK FORWARD TO IT. NO MATTER WHAT WE BELIEVE, OR FEAR, THE BIRTH OF AI IS INEVITABLE. THE ONLY REAL QUESTION IS, "WHEN?"

BY **ANIRUDH REGIDI**

What is AI? We've defined it as "the theory and development of computer systems able to perform tasks normally requiring human intelligence, such as visual perception, speech recognition, decision-making, and translation between languages." But is that all it is?

Visual perception? Facebook, military targeting systems and the NSA have already cracked that. Speech recognition and translation? Siri, Google Now, Cortana... need we say more? What about decision making? Computers are making decisions for us all the time, the most obvious example being in games such as Chess and Call of Duty.

So have we already created artificial intelligence? In a manner of speaking, yes we have. It's neither as glamorous nor as godlike as we imagine it to be, but AI, in some form or the other, has long since permeated our lives to the extent that we don't notice it anymore. In our minds, the true birth of AI would be the creation of a superhuman, a man-made God. We envision an entity that is intelligent beyond measure, but either bogged down by the frivolities of human emotion or oblivious of the human condition – an entity that is a tyrant or a God (benevolent or otherwise), or maybe just a slave.

Essentially, our ideal of "true" AI is one that is moral (on some level), emotional, creative and hopefully, rational by our standards; as mentioned earlier, a superhuman. But this is exactly what's driving

our fear, why Elon Musk and even Stephen Hawking say things like: "One can imagine (AI) outsmarting financial markets, out-inventing human researchers, out-manipulating human leaders, and developing weapons we cannot even understand. Whereas the short-term impact of AI depends on who controls it, the long-term impact depends on whether it can be controlled at all."

Even if we were to assume the worst: that we did create AI, and for some obscure reason it set about wiping out the human race, the real question we must ask ourselves is, "Are we so special?" Borrowing a quote from Time magazine, "The better these seemingly soulless machines

get at doing things people do, the more plausible it seems that we could be soulless machines too."

So are we anywhere near that robot and spiritual apocalypse? Let's find out.

DELVING DEEP

We'll begin with Deep Blue. The first computer (some went so far as to call it AI) to beat Gary Kasparov at a game of chess. Many consider Deep Blue to be a milestone, heralding the birth of AI and the downfall of the human race. But aren't we making too big a deal about nothing? Hell, any of the thousands of different chess apps on the app store are sure to defeat you in chess today. Since when did chess



IMAGE SOURCE: THE GUARDIAN

God created man in his own image and then man returned the favor